

Hallmark of Humility

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The Santhals of Odisha is certainly in the peak of their glory these days. Both the President of India, Draupadi Murmu, and the Chief Minister of the state, Mohan Charan Majhi, hail from Santhal tribe, one of the largest tribal communities in eastern India. Majhi becoming the first tribal CM of Odisha has created a historic milestone that has empowered a long-marginalised group and reflects inclusion in the highest level of state leadership.

The tittle "People's Chief Minister" for Majhi stems from a combination of symbolic gestures, substantive governance choices and his personal background that collectively portray him as someone closely connected with the masses of Odisha. Majhi has earned this with munch effort. He has all the ingredients of simplicity rising to the position of Chief Minister, which have an uncanny resemblance with that of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Let us examine them one by one.

Apart from his humble origin and tribal identity, Majhi started his political career at the panchayat level and worked his way up, representing the tribal-dominated district of Keonjhar. This progression has built his image as someone who understands the struggles of the common man. Unlike many political figures, Majhi has been seen living modestly, reflecting his connection to rural life and his constituents.



Besides his grassroots political journey, Majhi has won the hearts through his symbolic gestures that resonate with the common people. On his first day in office, Majhi was seen touching the ground with reverence before entering the Chief Minister's Office (CMO), a powerful symbolic act of humility and service. People are comparing this gesture with that of Modi when the Prime Minister had bowed and touched his forehead on the steps of Parliament the day he took office for the first time in 2014.

Through his people-centric governance and direct public engagements also, CM Majhi has won the confidence of the people of Odisha within a short span of one year. He has launched Jan Sampark Abhiyan, a public outreach program where ministers and officials engage with citizens directly. Such programs promote transparency and accessibility, regularly reviewing grievances and development projects in districts personally.

Notably, the 'Lakhpati Didi' initiative of Majhi government has topped the national chart, showcasing his successful focus on women's economic empowerment. It has boosted the rural women's income through Self-Help Groups (SHGs) in a big way. Take the case of 'Subhadra', the most popular flagship scheme of Majhi government. It has become the talk of the town with crores of women in Odisha being benefitted by it.

His commitment to SC/ST upliftment has also gone well with the marginalised sections of the society. Measures like renovation of tribal hostels, conversion of tribal schools into higher secondary institutions and development of 500 model tribal villages as well as implementation of interest-free loans and SHG support in rural and tribal regions have reinforces his image as a leader for socially disadvantaged groups.

On the front of infrastructure and connectivity for the masses, "Zero Accident Day" initiative and installation of smart safety devices in buses show a commitment to public safety. Similarly, launch of Shri Jagannath Express bus service connecting Odisha to spiritual and cultural centres reflects cultural sensitivity and support for religious tourism accessible to all. Expansion of rural banking and telecom networks to ensure that digital and financial inclusion has reached Odisha's remote villages too.

The Majhi government has also promptly responded to people's issues like it has increased social security pensions to Rs 3,500 per month for senior citizens and persons with disabilities and launched a relief package for over 9 lakh kendu leaf workers, providing essentials like slippers, hats and blankets to them. The government has ordered show-cause notices to 300 revenue officers for land registration irregularities, signaling seriousness about accountability and anti-corruption.

CM Majhi's non-elitist demeanour, use of regional language and open-door approach have led many to describe him as approachable and relatable. It has been seen that Majhi would often visit the home of an ordinary man and have typical Odia food like 'Pakhala Bhaat' and 'Santula' with ease there. His mixing with common people in such an amicable manner has not only enhanced his public image and reception, it has even forced his political opponents to acknowledge his clean image and sincere intent.

Hence, Mohan Charan Majhi is seen as a "People's Chief Minister" not because of rhetoric, but due to a combination of his grounded personal history, visible humility and accessibility, a focused governance agenda on tribals, rural poor, women and youth as well as cultural resonance and local identity promotion. He represents a shift toward inclusive leadership in Odisha — prioritising equity, outreach and respect for the people he governs.